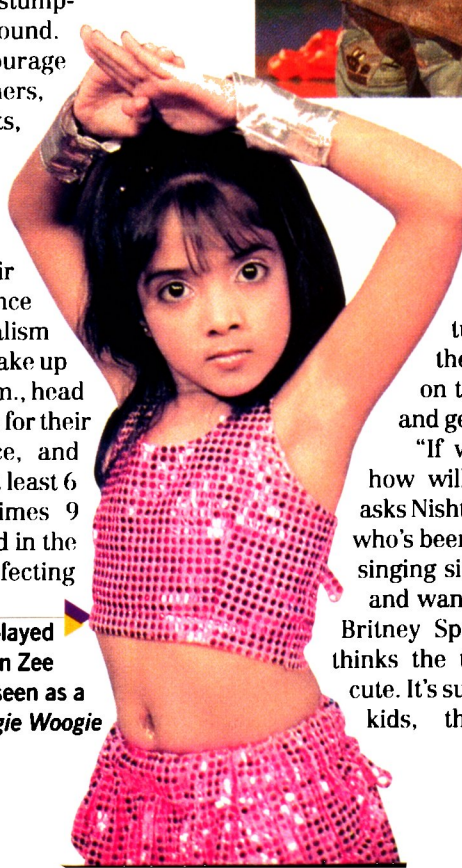


college and meeting friends, she's recording. But we tell her that to achieve one thing, you have to give up another. She can have all the fun when she reaches her goal," he says, as he watches her getting her hair fixed by a stylist on the shoot of *Ek Se Badhkar Ek*, Zee TV's new show where television actors and singers from reality shows form jodis and compete with others. Tarun Mehra, marketing head, Zee TV, says, "It's always made to sound that children on television are growing up too fast, but the fact is that children, in general, are growing up too fast. Yes, it is unfortunate that sometimes parents want to live their life through kids but then parents are pushy when it comes to sports and studies too."

Glamour has become all-too-easily attainable and dreams are being transformed into reality at a lightening speed. Tanu participated in the first and second season of *Li'l Champs* and *Antakshari for Kids* respectively, says her mother Neelam, and already is the proud owner of a make-up kit because she doesn't like going out without her lipstick in place. "I think I have that something special in me that will make me an actress," she says, instantly chipping in that she's always wanted to be famous. But screen idols are not what she's hankering after. "*Main apni favourite hoon* (I'm my favourite)," is her spitfire reply, stumping adults all around. Aided by an entourage of choreographers, make-up artists, dress designers and production people, these little energy bundles can put their years of experience and professionalism to shame. They wake up religiously at 9 a.m., head for dance practice for their next performance, and from 10 a.m. to at least 6 p.m. and sometimes 9 p.m., stay closeted in the practice hall, perfecting

KHUSHI DUBEY, 8, played the young naagin on Zee TV's *Naagin*. Last seen as a participant on *Boogie Woogie*



KID NATION

- Most reality shows are shot on gruelling deadlines, with two episodes being canned in a day and the shoot time stretching well past the midnight.
- No show has a counsellor who can keep a check on exuberant parents and over-enthusiastic children.
- There are no guidelines for working children, along the lines of Ofcom in the UK.
- The intense competitions are causing breakdowns. Anamika Choudhary from *Sa Re Ga Ma Pa Li'l Champs* broke down in the middle of her performance.

Spears's *Hit Me Baby One More Time* are completely unaware of her troubled present. Nagchoudhury, originally from Udaipur, has been staying in Mumbai with her mother who apart from being her teenage daughter's support has also been consoling nervous kids who fear elimination more than anything else. And it is to escape this elimination monster that 13-year-old Loria Dhosi, also from Udaipur, practiced despite fever, 12-year-old Deepak Tirkey from a village in Jharkhand performed after popping a Crocin and Nagchoudhury wore a tightly-wound *pagdi* around her head for close to eight hours despite the fact

SALMAN KHAN cheering the participants of *Star Voice of India Chhote Ustad*



their 1, 2, 3, 4s. But pack-up for the choreographers doesn't mean pack-up for them. After returning to the flat, the children switch on the CD player again and get back to business.

"If we get tired, then how will we get ahead?" asks Nishtha Nagchoudhury, who's been learning classical singing since she was three and wants to be the Indian Britney Spears because she thinks the troubled singer is cute. It's surprising that these kids, though aware of

that her skin reacted to the material and broke out in a rash. "I hope this gets over soon. But since the shoot has started late, it looks like we'll be here till 5 a.m.," says Tirkey, who just like the majority on the show wants to be famous. Actor Raveena Tandon, one of the judges on the show, says that though children in general are aping adults, one cannot discount the platform television gives to contestants, especially from small towns. "They would have remained in their villages if it weren't for television. Through these shows, they get to be celebrities," she says, adding that it is sad that Santa Claus and the Tooth Fairy might soon be just a mirage.

Just like the ideal of an innocent childhood?